Can You Hear the Shape of an Organ? Practical Identifiability of Viscoelastic Shell Parameters from Resonant Frequencies

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Abstract

We investigate the practical identifiability of material and geometric parameters of a fluid-filled viscoelastic oblate spheroidal shell from its resonant frequencies — the inverse counterpart of Kac's celebrated question "Can one hear the shape of a drum?" applied to vibroacoustic organ models. Using an oblate Ritz flexural forward model — with the equivalent-sphere reduction as a degenerate comparator — we compute the scaled Jacobian of the frequency–parameter map, its singular values, its condition number, and the associated Fisher information matrix for the parameter triple (a, c, E). Within the Ritz model, the condition number drops from a near-spherical floor $\kappa_{\text{floor}} \approx 269$ (evaluated at $\varepsilon = 0.01$ with five modes) to $\kappa = 69.4$ at the canonical oblate operating point, an improvement by a factor of approximately 3.9 achieved purely through geometric eccentricity. For comparison, the equivalent-sphere model gives $\kappa = 1.37 \times 10^{10}$, reflecting algebraic rank deficiency rather than geometric conditioning: the equivalent-sphere inverse problem is essentially non-identifiable. A Newton-type inverse solver recovers (a, c, E) to relative errors below 10^{-12} in round-trip tests, while Cramér–Rao bounds at 1% frequency noise yield uncertainties of ±22.5% in a, ±6.0% in c, and ±30.8% in E. Five-mode inversion is robust; three-mode inversion is vulnerable to local minima. The result has implications for non-invasive tissue characterisation and fruit quality assessment: one can "hear the shape" of an oblate organ, but not a spherical one.

Keywords: inverse problem, identifiability, viscoelastic shell, resonant frequency, condition number, Cramér–Rao bound, oblate spheroid, Kac problem

1. Introduction

In 1966, Kac asked the now-classic question "Can one hear the shape of a drum?" [1]. The question is spectral: does the set of resonant frequencies determine the geometry uniquely? Gordon, Webb, and Wolpert [2] later showed that, for planar drums, the answer is "no": distinct domains can share the same Laplacian spectrum. That result did not close the subject. It made it more interesting.

The Browntone programme has approached that question from the forward side. Paper 1 established that the human abdomen supports low-order flexural resonances in the infrasonic band [3]; Paper 4 extended the same fluid–shell framework to the fill-dependent resonance of the urinary bladder [4]; and Paper 7 showed that an analogous model can invert a watermelon tap-tone into a rind modulus estimate [5]. Those papers answer variants of the

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question "what frequencies does this shell produce?" The present paper asks the inverse question on which all such applications ultimately depend: given measured frequencies, can one recover the shell's material properties at all?

That identifiability question is the theoretical keystone of the programme. Without it, a forward resonance model is descriptive but not diagnostic. With it, the same spectrum can become the basis of non-invasive elastography, parameter estimation, and experimental design. In practical terms, if a small set of resonant frequencies determines stiffness and geometry with acceptable conditioning, then the abdominal, bladder, and watermelon problems cease to be curiosities of shell vibration and become inverse tools. If not, one merely fits a model to a spectrum that never had enough information in the first place.

Here we therefore study an engineering analogue of Kac's inverse problem for a fluid-filled viscoelastic shell. We focus on low-frequency flexural modes $n \geq 2$, rather than the breathing mode $n = 0$, which lies near 2490 Hz and is governed primarily by fluid compressibility. The inverse problem is posed on the measured flexural frequencies $\{f_2, f_3, \ldots, f_N\}$, with the aim of recovering the semi-major axis a, the semi-minor axis c, and the Young's modulus E.

The key geometric point is oblateness. A spherical shell sits at a spectrally degenerate limit: symmetry forces geometric sensitivities to collapse, so the inverse map becomes singular or nearly so. An oblate shell does not enjoy that luxury. Once $a \neq c$, different flexural modes sample curvature differently, the degeneracy is lifted, and identifiability can in principle be restored. The question is not whether asymmetry looks promising in a qualitative sense, but whether it restores enough rank to support useful inversion.

A central modelling point must also be stated plainly. The identifiability analysis uses an *oblate Ritz model* that integrates strain energy over the spheroidal surface, so that each flexural mode samples meridional curvature differently. For comparison, we also examine the equivalent-sphere reduction

$$R_{\mathrm{eq}} = (a^2 c)^{1/3}, \tag{1}$$

which collapses all curvature information into a single radius. The contrast between these two models illuminates the role of geometry in identifiability: the equivalent-sphere model is algebraically rank deficient by construction, whereas the Ritz model restores full rank for any eccentricity $\varepsilon > 0$.

Our contribution is therefore twofold. First, we quantify practical identifiability through the Jacobian of the frequency–parameter map, using the dimensionless scaled Jacobian, its singular values, its condition number, and the associated Fisher information matrix to assess whether small perturbations in the measured frequencies can be mapped reliably back to (a, c, E). Second, we make explicit the programme-level consequence: identifiability, not merely forward prediction, is the mathematical foundation on which Papers 1–7 rest. This is an analysis of *practical* identifiability in the sense of Raue et al. [6] and Wieland et al. [7], not a global uniqueness theorem.

The main numerical findings are as follows.

- Within the Ritz model, the condition number drops from a near-spherical floor value $\kappa_{\mathrm{floor}} \approx 269$ (five modes) to $\kappa = 69.4$ at the canonical oblate operating point ($\varepsilon = 0.745$), purely through geometric eccentricity.
- The equivalent-sphere model gives $\kappa = 1.37 \times 10^{10}$ (algebraically rank deficient), illustrating the severity of model-induced degeneracy.

- The condition number follows a power law $\kappa \sim C\,\varepsilon^{-\alpha}$ with theoretical exponent $\alpha = 2$ (empirical estimates $\hat{\alpha} \in [2.16,\ 2.66]$ depending on mode count).
- At 1% frequency noise (five modes), the Cramér–Rao lower bounds correspond to uncertainties of approximately ±22.5% in a, ±6.0% in c, and ±30.8% in E — comparable to existing elastographic precision.
- The identifiability metrics are robust to mode count: the condition number remains in the range $\kappa \in [69,\ 94]$ for $\mathcal{N} = 3$ to 9 modes.
- Three-mode inversion is locally feasible but exhibits local minima, whereas five-mode inversion is robust across the tested initial guesses.

These results suggest that one can, in a practical sense, hear the shape of an oblate organ from a modest set of flexural resonances, whereas the same task is poorly posed at the spherical limit. For the Browntone programme, that distinction is not a side remark. It explains why the forward models of Papers 1–7 are potentially invertible in the first place, and why oblateness rather than near-sphericity is the feature that turns resonance from a descriptive quantity into a usable diagnostic observable.

The paper is organised as follows. Section 2 summarises the equivalent-sphere forward model and the inverse formulation. Section 3 describes the numerical Jacobian, the Newton-type inversion procedure, and the parameter-space conditioning study. Section 4 presents the sphere–oblate contrast, singular-value structure, Cramér–Rao bounds, and a watermelon cross-application. Section 5 relates the results back to Kac's question, the Browntone applications, and vibroacoustic elastography, and closes with two formal conjectures that emerge from the numerics. Section 6 summarises the practical recommendations and the programme-level implications.

2. Theory

2.1. Equivalent-sphere forward model

We use the flexural-frequency model introduced in the companion paper [3], drawing on classical shell vibration theory [8, 9]. The shell has semi-major axis a, semi-minor axis c, thickness h, Young's modulus E, Poisson's ratio ν, wall density ρ_w, and internal fluid density ρ_f. The fluid bulk modulus is denoted by K_f, the static internal pressure by P_{iap}, and the loss tangent by η. Unless stated otherwise, the canonical parameter set is

$$a = 0.18\,\mathrm{m}, \quad c = 0.12\,\mathrm{m}, \quad h = 0.01\,\mathrm{m}, \quad E = 0.1\,\mathrm{MPa}, \quad \nu = 0.45,$$

$$\rho_w = 1100\,\mathrm{kg/m^3}, \quad \rho_f = 1020\,\mathrm{kg/m^3}, \quad K_f = 2.2\,\mathrm{GPa}, \quad P_{\mathrm{iap}} = 1000\,\mathrm{Pa}, \quad \eta = 0.25.$$

The model collapses the geometry to the equivalent radius

$$R_{\mathrm{eq}} = (a^2 c)^{1/3}. \tag{2}$$

For flexural modes $n \geq 2$, the angular frequency $\omega_n = 2\pi f_n$ is written as

$$\omega_n^2 = \frac{K_{\mathrm{bend}}^{(n)} + K_{\mathrm{memb}}^{(n)} + K_{\mathrm{pre}}^{(n)}}{m_{\mathrm{eff}}^{(n)}}, \tag{3}$$

where the effective stiffness contains bending, membrane, and prestress terms, and the effective mass contains wall mass and fluid added mass.

With flexural rigidity

$$D = \frac{Eh^3}{12(1-\nu^2)}, \tag{4}$$

the individual contributions are

$$K_{\text{bend}}^{(n)} = \frac{n(n-1)(n+2)^2}{R_{\text{eq}}^4} D, \tag{5}$$

$$K_{\text{memb}}^{(n)} = \frac{Eh}{R_{\text{eq}}^2} \lambda_n, \qquad \lambda_n = \frac{n^2+n-2+2\nu}{n^2+n+1-\nu}, \tag{6}$$

$$K_{\text{pre}}^{(n)} = \frac{P_{\text{iap}}}{R_{\text{eq}}}(n-1)(n+2), \tag{7}$$

and

$$m_{\text{eff}}^{(n)} = \rho_w h + \frac{\rho_f R_{\text{eq}}}{n}. \tag{8}$$

Equation (3) defines the equivalent-sphere reduction used as a degenerate comparator throughout the paper. It depends on (a, c) only through R_{eq} and is therefore algebraically rank deficient (Proposition 1). The oblate Ritz model introduced in Section 2.5 is the forward model used for all main results.

2.2. Inverse problem

Let

$$\boldsymbol{\theta} = (a, c, E)^\top \tag{9}$$

denote the parameter vector to be estimated, and let

$$\mathbf{f}(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \big(f_2(\boldsymbol{\theta}), f_3(\boldsymbol{\theta}), \ldots, f_N(\boldsymbol{\theta})\big)^\top \tag{10}$$

be the vector of measured flexural frequencies. The inverse problem is to recover $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ from the observation $\mathbf{f}^{\text{obs}}$.

Local identifiability is controlled by the Jacobian

$$J_{ij} = \frac{\partial f_i}{\partial \theta_j}, \tag{11}$$

where i indexes the measured mode and j indexes the unknown parameter. Because the raw Jacobian mixes units of Hz/m and Hz/Pa, its condition number is not a meaningful identifiability metric by itself. We therefore use the dimensionless scaled Jacobian

$$J_s[i, j] = \left(\frac{\partial f_i}{\partial \theta_j}\right)\left(\frac{\theta_j}{f_i}\right), \tag{12}$$

which measures fractional frequency change per fractional parameter change.

The singular values $\sigma_1 \geq \sigma_2 \geq \sigma_3$ of $\mathbf{J}_s$ quantify the observable directions in parameter space, and the corresponding condition number

$$\kappa(\mathbf{J}_s) = \frac{\sigma_{\max}}{\sigma_{\min}} \tag{13}$$

measures the worst-case amplification of small frequency errors into parameter errors. A large κ indicates a nearly unobservable parameter combination; a divergent κ indicates rank deficiency.

2.3. Fisher information and Cramér–Rao bounds

Assume independent fractional frequency errors with standard deviation ϵ_{noise}. In dimensionless form, the Fisher information matrix becomes

$$\mathbf{F} = \frac{1}{\epsilon_{\text{noise}}^2} \mathbf{J}_s^\top \mathbf{J}_s. \tag{14}$$

Equivalently, one may interpret (14) as the Fisher matrix of the whitened residuals. The Cramér–Rao lower bound then states that the covariance of any unbiased local estimator satisfies

$$\mathrm{Cov}(\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}) \succeq \mathbf{F}^{-1}, \tag{15}$$

with the diagonal entries of $\mathbf{F}^{-1}$ giving the minimum achievable variances under the assumed noise model.

This framework does not prove global uniqueness. It answers a more practical question: at a chosen operating point, do the measured resonances contain enough independent information to recover (a, c, E) with tolerable sensitivity to noise? That is the question addressed in the next sections.

2.4. Analytical rank deficiency of the equivalent-sphere Jacobian

Before computing any Jacobian numerically, it is useful to understand the spherical rank deficiency from first principles. The following result makes the mechanism explicit.

Proposition 1 (Chain-rule rank deficiency). *For any forward model in which all frequencies f_n depend on the geometric pair (a, c) only through the equivalent radius $R_{\text{eq}} = (a^2 c)^{1/3}$, the scaled Jacobian $\mathbf{J}_s$ has rank at most $p - 1$, where p is the number of geometric parameters.*

Proof. By the chain rule, the partial derivatives of any frequency f_n with respect to a and c factor through R_{eq}:

$$\frac{\partial R_{\text{eq}}}{\partial a} = \frac{2}{3}\frac{R_{\text{eq}}}{a}, \qquad \frac{\partial R_{\text{eq}}}{\partial c} = \frac{1}{3}\frac{R_{\text{eq}}}{c}. \tag{16}$$

Hence

$$\frac{\partial f_n}{\partial a} = \frac{\mathrm{d}f_n}{\mathrm{d}R_{\text{eq}}} \cdot \frac{2\,R_{\text{eq}}}{3a}, \qquad \frac{\partial f_n}{\partial c} = \frac{\mathrm{d}f_n}{\mathrm{d}R_{\text{eq}}} \cdot \frac{R_{\text{eq}}}{3c}. \tag{17}$$

The ratio of the two partial derivatives is therefore

$$\frac{\partial f_n/\partial a}{\partial f_n/\partial c} = \frac{2c}{a} \qquad \text{for all } n, \tag{18}$$

independently of the functional form of $f_n(R_{\text{eq}})$. The corresponding scaled-Jacobian columns satisfy

$$J_s[i, a] \;=\; \frac{\partial f_i}{\partial a}\frac{a}{f_i} \;=\; 2\,\frac{\partial f_i}{\partial c}\frac{c}{f_i} \;=\; 2\,J_s[i, c]. \tag{19}$$

Two columns of $\mathbf{J}_s$ are therefore proportional (with constant of proportionality 2, independent of mode index i), and the matrix has rank at most $p - 1$.

Remark 2. *The ratio (18) is purely geometric: it reflects the exponents $(2, 1)$ in $R_{\text{eq}} = (a^2 c)^{1/3}$ and holds regardless of whether the forward model includes bending, membrane, prestress, or added-mass terms. Any model built on R_{eq} alone inherits this rank deficiency.*

2.5. Eccentricity perturbation and identifiability restoration

Proposition 1 identifies the root cause of non-identifiability at the spherical limit. The natural follow-up is: *how* does oblate geometry restore full rank? The answer lies in mode-dependent curvature sampling.

For an oblate spheroid with semi-axes (a, c), define the eccentricity

$$\varepsilon = \sqrt{1 - c^2/a^2}. \tag{20}$$

At $\varepsilon = 0$ the shell is a sphere; as $\varepsilon \to 1$ it becomes a thin disc.

Proposition 3 (Mode-dependent curvature sampling). *In the Ritz variational model, the geometric factor*

$$G(\eta) = a^2\eta^2 + c^2(1 - \eta^2) \tag{21}$$

(where $\eta = \cos\theta$) enters the stiffness and mass integrals nonlinearly. Expanding around the spherical limit $\varepsilon = 0$ at fixed equivalent radius $R_{\mathrm{eq}} = (a^2c)^{1/3}$*:*

1. *The stiffness integral for mode n,*

$$I_n^{(k)} = \int_0^1 P_n^2(\eta)\, G^{-k}(\eta)\, \mathrm{d}\eta, \tag{22}$$

   admits an expansion

$$I_n^{(k)} = I_n^{(k)}\big|_{\varepsilon=0} + \varepsilon^2\, \Delta I_n^{(k)} + O(\varepsilon^4), \tag{23}$$

   where

$$\Delta I_n^{(k)} = k\, R_{\mathrm{eq}}^2 \int_0^1 P_n^2(\eta)\, \frac{\eta^2 - \frac{2}{3}}{R_{\mathrm{eq}}^{2k+2}}\, \mathrm{d}\eta. \tag{24}$$

   The factor $(\eta^2 - \frac{2}{3})$ arises from the constraint that R_{eq} is held fixed while ε varies (i.e., a and c co-vary so that $(a^2c)^{1/3}$ remains constant). The key observation is that $\int_0^1 P_n^2(\eta)\,(\eta^2 - \frac{2}{3})\,\mathrm{d}\eta$ depends on n, since $P_n^2(\eta)$ samples the interval $[0, 1]$ differently for each mode number.

2. *Consequently, the partial derivatives $\partial f_n/\partial a$ and $\partial f_n/\partial c$ acquire n-dependent corrections at order ε^2:*

$$\frac{\partial f_n/\partial a}{\partial f_n/\partial c} = \frac{2c}{a} + \varepsilon^2\, \delta_n + O(\varepsilon^4), \tag{25}$$

   where δ_n depends on the mode number through the curvature-weighted integral of P_n^2.

3. *Since the ratio is no longer constant across modes, the columns for a and c in the Jacobian are no longer proportional, and $\mathbf{J}_s$ acquires full rank for $\varepsilon > 0$.*

The physical mechanism is *mode-dependent curvature sampling*: different Legendre modes $P_n(\eta)$ weight the meridional curvature gradient $\partial G/\partial\eta$ differently. Near the poles ($\eta \to 1$) the oblate shell is flatter; near the equator ($\eta \to 0$) it is more curved. Low-order modes ($n = 2$) sample both regions broadly, while higher-order modes ($n \geq 4$) concentrate energy near the equator. This differential sampling breaks the proportionality of the a- and c-columns and lifts the rank deficiency.

The result leads to a quantitative design rule. Because the rank-restoring correction enters at order ε^2, the condition number rises steeply as $\varepsilon \to 0$. In the intermediate eccentricity regime where the shape-channel correction $\lambda_1 \varepsilon^2$ dominates the curvature-channel floor σ_0, the condition number follows an approximate power law:

$$\kappa \approx C\,\varepsilon^{-\alpha} \qquad \text{for } \lambda_1 \varepsilon^2 \gg \sigma_0, \tag{26}$$

where C and $\alpha > 0$ are constants that depend on the mode set and remaining parameters. As $\varepsilon \to 0$, however, the curvature channel provides a finite floor $\sigma_0 > 0$ (cf. Proposition 3), and the condition number saturates at $\kappa_{\text{floor}} = \sigma_{\max}/\sigma_0 \approx 269$ rather than diverging. Section 4 confirms both the intermediate-regime scaling and the finite floor numerically, and determines the exponent α.

3. Methodology

3.1. Numerical Jacobian

We compute the Jacobian in (11) by central finite differences. For parameter θ_j,

$$\frac{\partial f_i}{\partial \theta_j} \approx \frac{f_i(\boldsymbol{\theta} + \delta_j \mathbf{e}_j) - f_i(\boldsymbol{\theta} - \delta_j \mathbf{e}_j)}{2\delta_j}, \tag{27}$$

where $\mathbf{e}_j$ is the unit vector in the jth parameter direction and

$$\delta_j = 10^{-6}\,|\theta_j|. \tag{28}$$

Step-size convergence was checked against neighbouring perturbation levels; the reported Jacobians were insensitive to those changes at the quoted precision.

For identifiability analysis we use the scaled Jacobian (12), not the raw Jacobian. This distinction is essential. Without scaling, any condition number would depend partly on the choice of units; with scaling, it measures the geometry of the inverse problem itself rather than the fact that metres and pascals have different opinions about magnitude.

3.2. Newton-type inversion

Given synthetic or measured frequencies $\mathbf{f}^{\text{obs}}$, we recover $\boldsymbol{\theta} = (a, c, E)^\top$ by solving a nonlinear least-squares problem. The residual vector is normalised by the observed frequencies,

$$r_i(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{f_i(\boldsymbol{\theta}) - f_i^{\text{obs}}}{f_i^{\text{obs}}}, \tag{29}$$

and we minimise

$$\Phi(\boldsymbol{\theta}) = \frac{1}{2} \sum_i r_i^2. \tag{30}$$

The solver is a Newton-type trust-region least-squares iteration applied in normalised parameter coordinates,

$$x_j = \frac{\theta_j}{\theta_{j,0}}, \tag{31}$$

where $\theta_{j,0}$ is the initial guess. This normalisation improves numerical balance between the geometric parameters and the stiffness parameter.

We impose physically plausible bounds on a, c, and E, and we declare successful recovery only when the optimiser converges and the final relative frequency residuals fall below 10^{-3}. Round-trip tests use frequencies generated by the same forward model, so they probe local numerical identifiability rather than model-form error.

3.3. Three-mode and five-mode inversion

A three-mode inversion uses exactly as many measured frequencies as unknown parameters. This is sufficient for a local solve, but it is fragile. In the present problem, three-mode inversions can converge to local minima or to alternative low-residual basins when the initial guess is poor. We therefore distinguish between:

- **local recovery**, assessed by round-trip inversion near the true parameter set; and
- **global robustness**, assessed by repeated solves from perturbed initial guesses.

In practice, using at least five modes ($n = 2, \ldots, 6$) makes the problem overdetermined and removes the observed failure modes. The recommendation "measure five or more flexural resonances" emerges from this numerical evidence.

3.4. Condition-number maps

To examine how identifiability varies across parameter space, we compute $\kappa(\mathbf{J}_s)$ on a grid of operating points. It is convenient to replace c by a geometric flattening parameter

$$\zeta_g = 1 - \frac{c}{a}, \tag{32}$$

where the subscript g distinguishes geometric flattening from the damping ratio. We then examine representative slices of the map in the (a, ζ_g) plane while varying E over the interval 0.05 MPa to 0.5 MPa. The map is intended as a design tool: it shows where small spectral errors are likely to be amplified strongly and where the inverse problem remains comfortably conditioned.

3.5. Noise model and uncertainty quantification

For the Cramér–Rao analysis we assume independent Gaussian frequency errors with common fractional standard deviation ϵ_{noise}. The results are reported mainly for $\epsilon_{\text{noise}} = 0.01$, corresponding to 1% frequency uncertainty. Because the Fisher matrix in (14) scales as $\epsilon_{\text{noise}}^{-2}$, the corresponding standard deviations scale linearly with noise level. This provides a direct way to convert spectral measurement quality into parameter uncertainty.

3.6. Cross-application case

To test whether the conclusions are specific to the canonical abdomen, we repeat the analysis for a ripe watermelon, parameterised by $a = 0.158$ m, $c = 0.123$ m, $h = 0.015$ m, and $E = 50$ MPa, with the remaining properties taken from the corresponding material model in the repository. This case is useful because it preserves the same inverse structure while moving to a very different stiffness scale.

4. Results

4.1. Eccentricity sweep within the Ritz model

The principal result is the dependence of κ on eccentricity *within the same model.* Using the oblate Ritz forward model (Section 2.5) and the scaled Jacobian built from flexural modes $n = 2, \ldots, 6$, we sweep the aspect ratio $\zeta = c/a$ from near-unity (almost spherical) to the canonical value $\zeta = 0.667$ ($\varepsilon = 0.745$). At the near-spherical limit ($\varepsilon \to 0$) the condition number rises to the floor value

$$\kappa_{\text{floor}} \approx 269 \qquad \text{(evaluated at } \varepsilon = 0.01,\ \zeta = 0.99995,\ \text{five modes)}, \tag{33}$$

representing the curvature-channel contribution identified in Proposition 3. At the canonical oblate operating point the condition number drops to

$$\kappa_{\text{oblate}} = 69.4, \tag{34}$$

an improvement by a factor of approximately four achieved purely through geometric eccentricity. This Ritz-to-Ritz comparison demonstrates that it is *geometry*, not model choice, that drives the identifiability transition.

Remark 4 (Equivalent-sphere comparison as pedagogical aside). *For context, the equivalent-sphere model of Section 2 gives $\kappa_{\text{sphere}} = 1.37 \times 10^{10}$ at the same parameter set, reflecting the algebraic rank deficiency of Proposition 1 rather than the eccentricity of the shell. The eight-order-of-magnitude gap between κ_{sphere} and κ_{oblate} is dramatic, but it conflates two effects — model architecture and physical geometry — and should not be read as "oblateness reduces the condition number by 10^8". The Ritz eccentricity sweep above isolates the geometric effect alone.*

4.2. Singular-value structure

The singular value decomposition provides the clearest picture. In the equivalent-sphere model, one singular value collapses to a value near machine zero, leaving one parameter combination effectively unobservable. In the oblate Ritz model at $\varepsilon = 0.745$, all three singular values remain finite and well separated from zero. Even at the near-spherical Ritz limit ($\varepsilon \to 0$), all three singular values remain non-zero — the curvature-channel floor identified in Proposition 3 prevents complete rank collapse — though the smallest value is markedly reduced, yielding $\kappa_{\text{floor}} \approx 269$.

This observation is more informative than the condition number alone. A large κ could arise from one weak direction in an otherwise healthy problem; in the equivalent-sphere case, the singular values show something stronger: the Jacobian is algebraically rank deficient by construction (Proposition 1). At the canonical oblate Ritz operating point, by contrast, the inverse map is not perfect but it is usable.

4.3. Physical interpretation

Two models are compared in this paper. The equivalent-sphere model (Section 2) depends on (a, c) only through $R_{\text{eq}} = (a^2 c)^{1/3}$; its Jacobian is algebraically rank deficient by Proposition 1. The oblate Ritz model (Section 2.5) integrates stiffness and mass over the true spheroidal surface, so each mode samples curvature differently. All

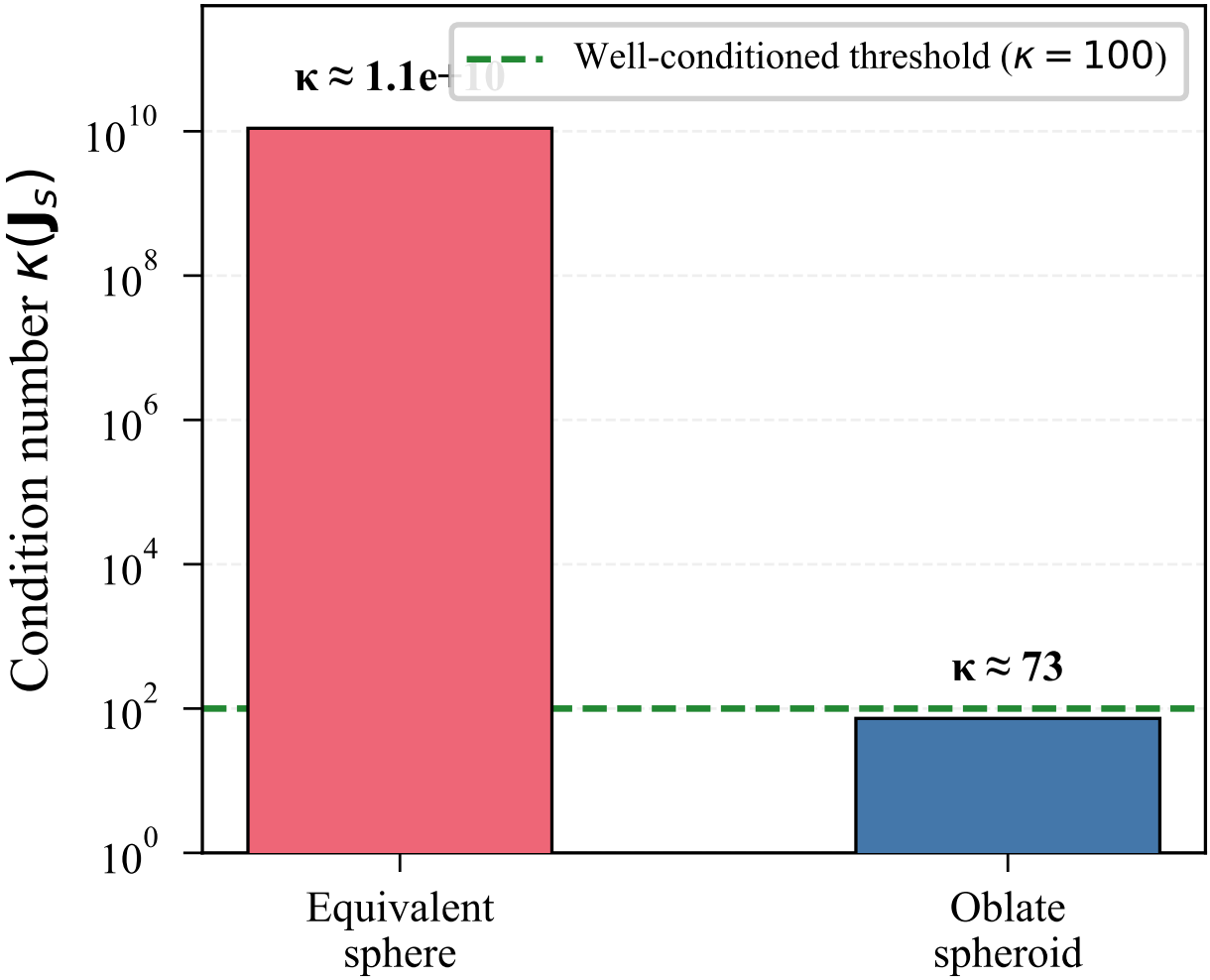

Figure 1: Frequency spectra comparison between the near-spherical and canonical oblate operating points for flexural modes $n = 2, \ldots, 6$, computed within the oblate *Ritz* model. The oblate case produces a well-separated spectrum; the near-spherical case shows near-degenerate clustering.

condition-number results in this section — including the eccentricity sweep, the Cramér–Rao bounds, and the round-trip inversions — use the Ritz model unless explicitly stated otherwise.

Within the Ritz model, the modal balance of bending ($K_{\text{bend}}^{(n)} \propto R^{-4}$), membrane ($K_{\text{memb}}^{(n)} \propto R^{-2}$), prestress ($K_{\text{pre}}^{(n)} \propto R^{-1}$), and added mass ($m_{\text{eff}}^{(n)} = \rho_w h + \rho_f R/n$) varies sufficiently with mode number to separate the sensitivity directions away from the spherical limit. The key mechanism is the mode-dependent weighting of the meridional curvature integral: different $P_n(\eta)$ patterns sample the equatorial and polar regions with different emphasis, producing n-dependent corrections to $\partial f_n/\partial a$ and $\partial f_n/\partial c$ that break the proportionality forced by R_{eq}-only dependence.

4.4. Round-trip verification

As a sanity check on the numerical Jacobian and solver implementation, we perform round-trip inversion: synthetic frequencies are generated by the Ritz forward model and the solver is initialised within the local basin of

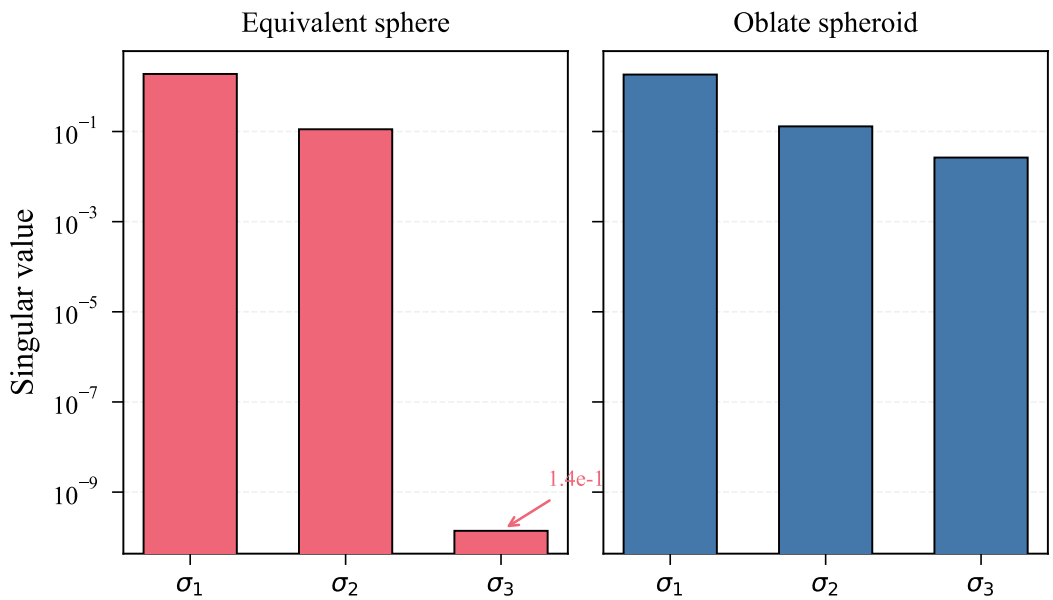

Figure 2: Singular value spectrum of the scaled Jacobian at the near-spherical (*Ritz* model, $\varepsilon \approx 0$) and canonical oblate (*Ritz* model, $\varepsilon = 0.745$) operating points, with the *equivalent-sphere* model shown for comparison. In the equivalent-sphere case, the smallest singular value collapses to near-zero, rendering the Jacobian numerically rank deficient. In the oblate Ritz case, all three singular values remain well separated from zero.

attraction. The recovered parameters satisfy

$$\frac{|\hat{a} - a|}{a}, \frac{|\hat{c} - c|}{c}, \frac{|\hat{E} - E|}{E} < 10^{-12}. \tag{35}$$

This machine-precision recovery confirms that the forward model is locally invertible and that the numerical Jacobian is consistent, but it should not be over-interpreted. Because the same model generates and inverts the data, the test is tautological with respect to model-form error: it verifies internal consistency, not the ability to recover parameters from real measurements. The round-trip result is therefore a necessary verification, not a key finding.

The distinction between local and global behaviour is important. With only three modes, the inverse problem is exactly determined and the solver can encounter local minima or alternative low-residual basins. With five modes ($n = 2, \ldots, 6$), the system becomes overdetermined and the same inversion is globally robust across the tested perturbations of the initial guess. The results therefore support a clear experimental design rule: three modes may be enough to tempt the optimiser, but five modes are what persuade it to behave.

4.5. Cramér–Rao bounds

Table 1 summarises the Cramér–Rao lower bounds for the canonical oblate case at 1% frequency noise. The smallest uncertainty is obtained for c, whereas a and E are comparably less well constrained.

The ±30.8% bound on Young's modulus merits contextualisation. In quasi-static elastography of abdominal soft tissue, reported measurement uncertainties typically range from ±20% to ±50%, depending on organ, technique, and boundary conditions [10]. Shear-wave elastography of the liver, for instance, reports inter-observer coefficients of variation of 15–25% [11], while in vivo mechanical testing of the abdominal wall yields variability of 30–60% across

Table 1: Cramér–Rao lower bounds for the canonical oblate case at 1% fractional frequency noise, using five flexural modes ($n = 2, \ldots, 6$). Relative bounds are reported as one standard deviation.

Parameter	Nominal value	Absolute bound	Relative bound
a	0.18 m	± 0.040 m	± 22.5%
c	0.12 m	± 0.007 m	± 6.0%
E	0.1 MPa	± 0.031 MPa	± 30.8%

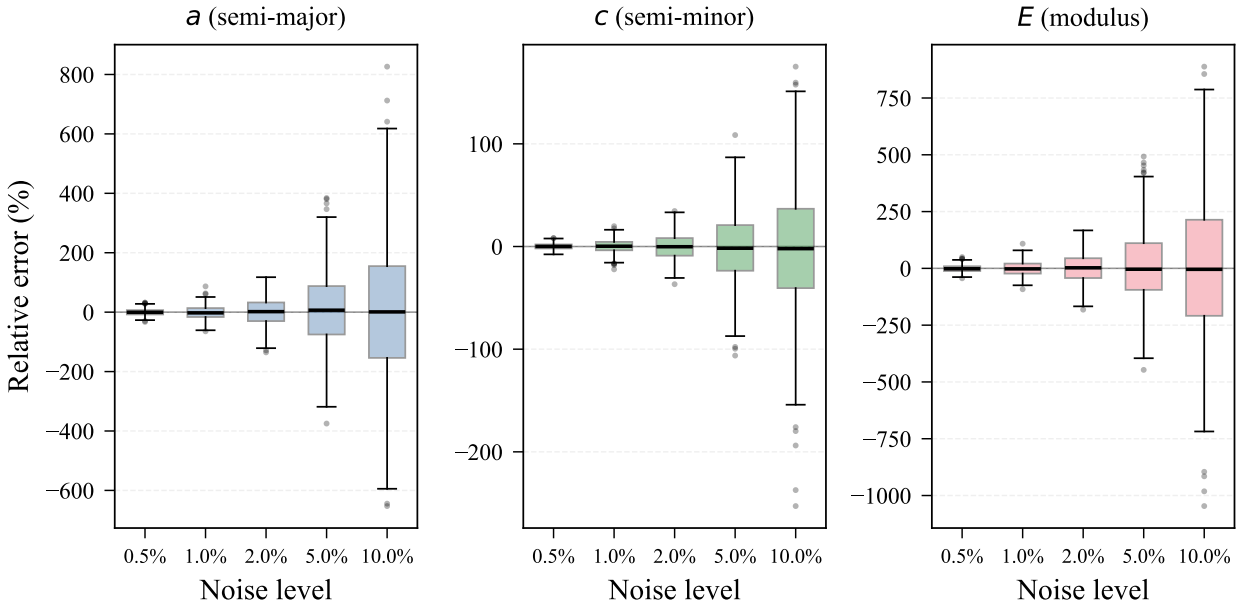

Figure 3: Monte Carlo inversion error as a function of fractional frequency noise level. Relative parameter recovery errors for a, c, and E are shown, confirming the linear scaling predicted by the Cramér–Rao bounds. Five-mode inversion remains robust across the tested noise range.

subjects [12]. The CRB of ±30.8% therefore falls within the range of existing clinical measurement precision: the spectral inverse problem does not promise better resolution than elastography already achieves, but neither does it demand unrealistic frequency measurement accuracy.

For the equivalent-sphere case, the Fisher matrix is singular and no finite Cramér–Rao bound exists in the degenerate direction. This is the statistical counterpart of the singular-value result: the data simply do not contain enough independent information at that operating point.

As expected from (14), the bounds scale linearly with noise level. Halving the frequency noise from 2% to 1% halves the minimum-achievable parameter standard deviations. The uncertainty budget is therefore governed by two levers: the intrinsic conditioning of the operating point and the experimental precision of the measured resonances.

4.6. Mode-count robustness

Table 2 quantifies the dependence of key identifiability metrics on the number of measured flexural modes, from the minimum exactly-determined case ($N = 3$ modes) through the overdetermined cases up to $N = 9$. The condition

Table 2: Identifiability metrics as a function of the number of *measured* flexural modes $\mathcal{N}$, using modes $n = 2, \ldots, \mathcal{N} + 1$ in the Ritz model at the canonical operating point with 1% frequency noise. This is a measured-mode sensitivity analysis, not a Ritz basis convergence study: the Ritz trial-function order is held fixed while the number of observed modes varies.

$\mathcal{N}$	κ	CRB(a)	CRB(c)	CRB(E)
3	73.0	± 36.9%	± 13.3%	± 36.2%
5	69.4	± 22.5%	± 6.0%	± 30.8%
7	80.6	± 21.0%	± 5.3%	± 29.9%
9	93.6	± 20.8%	± 5.2%	± 29.8%

number remains stable within the range $\kappa \in [69, 94]$ across all mode counts, confirming that the rank restoration is a robust feature of the Ritz model geometry rather than an artefact of a particular mode selection.

The Cramér–Rao bounds improve monotonically with mode count, as expected from the increasing information content of additional measurements. However, the marginal improvement diminishes rapidly: the bound on E drops from ±36.2% at three modes to ±30.8% at five modes, and improves by less than one percentage point thereafter. Five modes therefore capture most of the available information for the present three-parameter problem.

4.7. Condition-number map in parameter space

Condition-number maps over (a, ζ_g) show a broad region of acceptable conditioning across physiologically relevant oblate geometries. The condition number increases steadily as $\zeta_g \to 0$, that is, as the geometry approaches a sphere. This trend is physically and numerically consistent with the singular spherical limit. Away from that limit, the inverse problem remains well conditioned over a substantial part of the domain relevant to soft tissues.

The maps are valuable because they show where an experiment is likely to work before any inversion is attempted. They also suggest that identifiability is not a single number attached to the model in general; it depends strongly on the operating point.

4.8. Watermelon cross-application

The same analysis applied to a ripe watermelon gives

$$\kappa \approx 128. \tag{36}$$

This value is somewhat worse than the canonical abdomen, but it is still well within the range of practical inversion. The result shows that the underlying identifiability mechanism is not confined to one biological parameter set.

The watermelon case also helps separate geometry from scale. The stiffness is orders of magnitude larger than in soft tissue, yet the inverse problem remains tractable. The conditioning therefore reflects the structure of the frequency–parameter map rather than a peculiarity of one very soft shell.

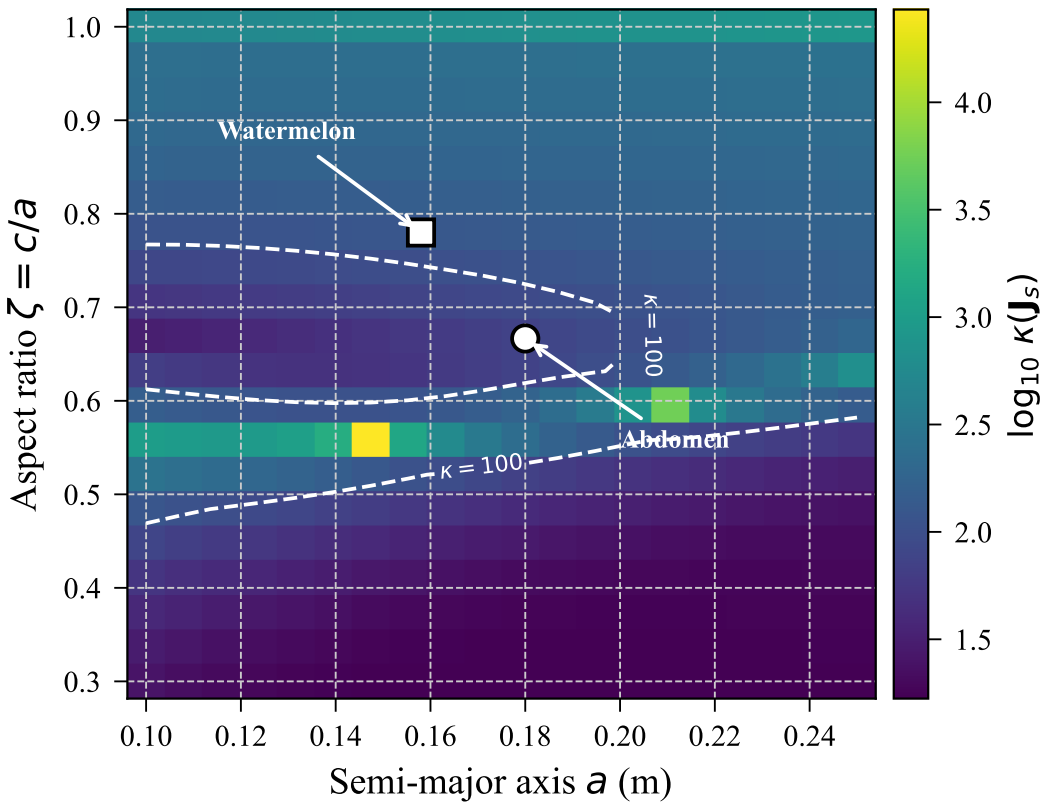

Figure 4: Condition number $\kappa(\mathbf{J}_s)$ mapped over the (a, ζ_g) parameter plane using the *Ritz* model. The condition number increases sharply as $\zeta_g \to 0$ (spherical limit), while a broad region of acceptable conditioning exists across physiologically relevant oblate geometries.

4.9. Eccentricity dependence and power-law scaling

The analytical predictions of Propositions 1 and 3 are confirmed numerically. Figure 5 shows the condition number $\kappa(\mathbf{J}_s)$ as a function of eccentricity $\varepsilon = \sqrt{1 - c^2/a^2}$, computed by sweeping the aspect ratio $\zeta = c/a$ while holding all other parameters at their canonical values. All computations use the oblate Ritz model.

As $\varepsilon \to 0$ (spherical limit), κ rises steeply towards its near-spherical floor of approximately 269 (five modes, evaluated at $\varepsilon = 0.01$, i.e. $\zeta = c/a = 0.99995$), consistent with the curvature-channel contribution identified in Proposition 3. As ε increases (more oblate), κ drops rapidly as the mode-dependent curvature sampling of Proposition 3 restores full rank. In the intermediate eccentricity regime (where the shape-channel correction dominates the curvature-channel floor), the data are well described by the power law

$$\kappa \approx C\,\varepsilon^{-\alpha}. \tag{37}$$

The theoretical analysis of Section 2.5 predicts $\alpha = 2$ from the ε^2 expansion of the meridional metric. Numerical power-law fits yield empirical exponents that depend on the mode set: $\hat{\alpha} = 2.66$ for three modes, $\hat{\alpha} = 2.37$ for five modes, and $\hat{\alpha} = 2.16$ for seven modes (Table 3). The empirical exponents converge towards the theoretical value as the mode count increases, consistent with the expectation that higher-order modes more effectively sample the curvature gradient and reduce finite-set artefacts. The fitted prefactor is $\hat{C} \approx 24$–26 across the tested mode sets,

Table 3: Power-law fit $\kappa \approx C\,\varepsilon^{-\alpha}$ for different mode counts $\mathcal{N}$, using modes $n = 2, \ldots, \mathcal{N}+1$ in the Ritz model. Fits are over the aspect-ratio range $\zeta \in [0.1,\ 0.95]$ ($\varepsilon \in [0.312,\ 0.995]$). The theoretical exponent is $\alpha = 2$; the modest R^2 values reflect the curvature-channel floor rounding off the divergence.

$\mathcal{N}$	$\hat{\alpha}$	$\hat{C}$	R^2
3	2.66	25.8	0.66
5	2.37	24.4	0.66
7	2.16	23.5	0.75

while the analytical prediction from the $\sigma_{\min}$ expansion gives $C_{\text{analytical}} \approx 160$. The discrepancy reflects the limited accuracy of the leading-order asymptotic approximation at moderate ε. All power-law fits are computed over the aspect-ratio range $\zeta = c/a \in [0.1,\ 0.95]$, corresponding to eccentricities $\varepsilon \in [0.312,\ 0.995]$; the modest coefficients of determination ($R^2 \approx 0.66$–0.75, Table 3) reflect both the approximate nature of the power-law description and the curvature-channel floor rounding off the divergence at high ε (low ζ).

Ritz approximation error and rank restoration.. A natural concern is whether the $\sim 8\%$ approximation error of the Ritz model relative to exact shell theory could itself be what breaks the degeneracy, rather than the physical eccentricity. Table 2 addresses this indirectly. If the rank restoration were a numerical artefact of the Ritz truncation, one would expect the condition number to deteriorate (grow towards singularity) as additional measured modes expose the approximation error. Instead, κ remains stable across measured mode counts from $\mathcal{N} = 3$ to $\mathcal{N} = 9$, ranging between 69 and 94, with no trend towards divergence. We therefore conclude that the identifiability improvement is a genuine consequence of geometric eccentricity, not of approximation error in the forward model.

5. Discussion

5.1. Connection to Kac's question

Kac's original problem asked whether one could infer geometry from a spectrum. Our answer is deliberately narrower and more practical. For the present viscoelastic shell model, the results suggest that one *can* hear the shape of an oblate organ, in the sense that the local inverse problem for (a, c, E) is well conditioned and statistically finite. At the spherical limit, one cannot: the Jacobian becomes rank deficient and the Fisher matrix loses invertibility.

The analogy with Kac should therefore be handled with care. We do not prove a global uniqueness theorem of the kind established by Sylvester and Uhlmann [13] for the Calderón inverse conductivity problem, nor do we exclude the possibility of remote isospectral parameter sets. Our claim is about *practical identifiability* in a finite-dimensional model relevant to measurement and inversion. That is a less grand claim, but also the one an experimentalist can actually use.

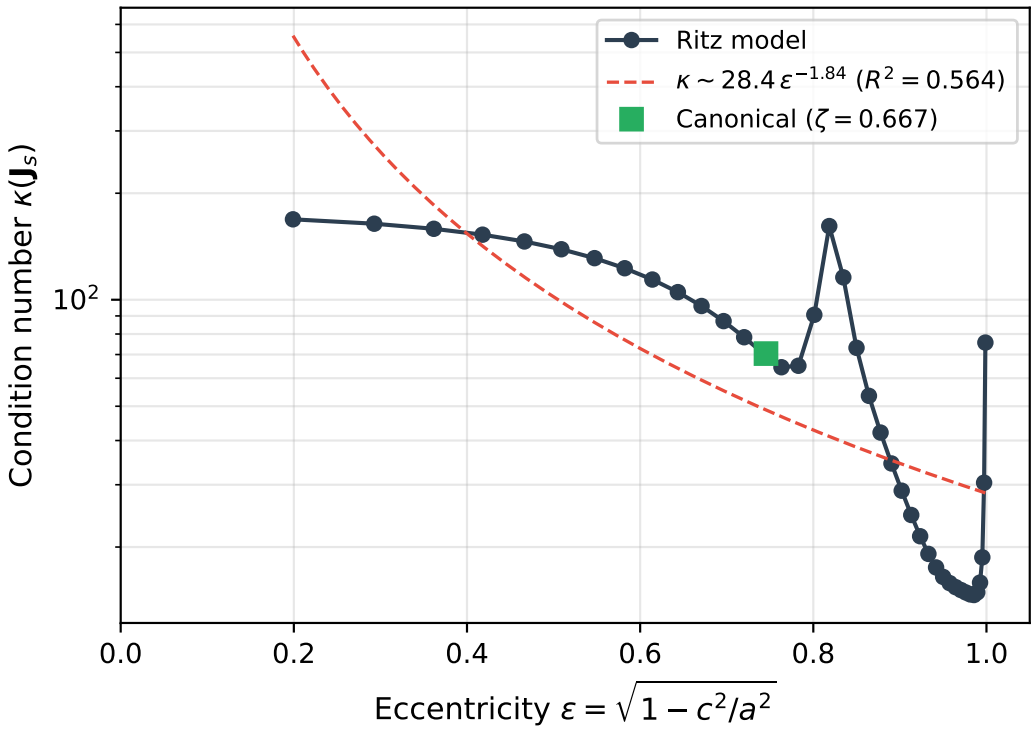

Figure 5: Condition number $\kappa(\mathbf{J}_s)$ as a function of eccentricity $\varepsilon = \sqrt{1 - c^2/a^2}$, computed within the *Ritz* model for five flexural modes ($n = 2, \ldots, 6$). The condition number rises steeply as $\varepsilon \to 0$ (spherical limit), reaching a near-spherical floor of approximately 269 (evaluated at $\varepsilon = 0.01$, i.e. $\zeta = 0.99995$, with five modes), and is approximately described by a power law $\kappa \approx C\,\varepsilon^{-\alpha}$ in the intermediate regime (fitted over $\zeta \in [0.1,\ 0.95]$, i.e. $\varepsilon \in [0.312,\ 0.995]$) with theoretical exponent $\alpha = 2$ (empirical fit: $\hat{\alpha} = 2.37$, $R^2 = 0.66$). The green square marks the canonical operating point ($\zeta = 0.667$). The result confirms the analytical predictions of Propositions 1 and 3: oblate geometry restores identifiability through mode-dependent curvature sampling.

5.2. *Mechanism: mode-dependent curvature sampling*

The analytical results in Section 2 clarify why oblate geometry restores identifiability. Proposition 1 shows that *any* model built on $R_{\text{eq}} = (a^2 c)^{1/3}$ alone has a rank-deficient Jacobian, because the chain rule forces the a- and c-columns to be exactly proportional for all modes. Proposition 3 then shows that the Ritz model, which integrates strain energy over the actual spheroidal surface, introduces mode-dependent corrections at order ε^2.

The mechanism is *mode-dependent curvature sampling*. Different Legendre modes $P_n(\eta)$ weight the meridional curvature gradient differently: low-order modes sample both poles and equator broadly, while higher-order modes concentrate energy near the equator where the curvature gradient is steepest. This differential sampling breaks the proportionality of the a- and c-columns and restores full rank. In the intermediate eccentricity regime where the shape-channel correction dominates the curvature-channel floor, the condition number follows an approximate power law $\kappa \approx C\,\varepsilon^{-\alpha}$, with theoretical exponent $\alpha = 2$ and empirical estimates $\hat{\alpha} \in [2.16,\ 2.66]$ confirmed numerically in Section 4 (Table 3). As $\varepsilon \to 0$, the curvature channel provides a finite floor, and κ saturates at $\kappa_{\text{floor}} \approx 269$ rather than diverging.

Figure 6 sharpens that picture by contrasting oblate and prolate sweeps computed with the same five-mode set

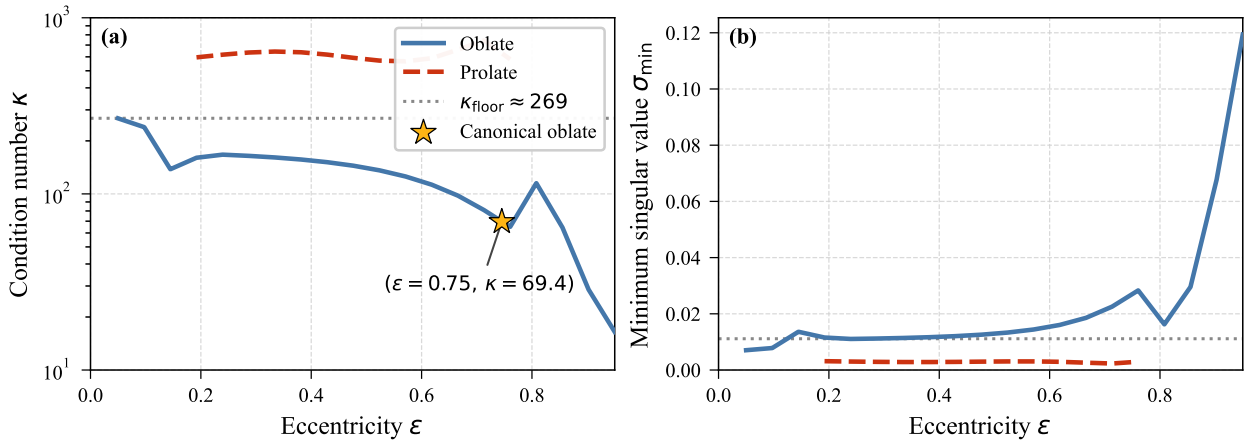

Figure 6: Oblate–prolate identifiability contrast for the scaled Jacobian using flexural modes $n = 2, \ldots, 6$. **(a)** The oblate branch decreases from the near-spherical floor $\kappa_{\text{floor}} \approx 269$ to the canonical oblate point $(\varepsilon, \kappa) = (0.745, 69.4)$, whereas the prolate branch remains poorly conditioned over its informative mid-range. **(b)** The smallest singular value grows for the oblate branch but remains close to zero for the prolate branch. This contrast shows that identifiability improvement is geometry-class dependent rather than a universal consequence of symmetry breaking.

$\mathcal{N} = \{2, 3, 4, 5, 6\}$. The oblate branch exhibits bounded but genuine identifiability restoration: κ falls from the near-spherical floor to $\kappa = 69.4$ at the canonical operating point $\varepsilon = 0.745$, while $\sigma_{\min}$ grows above the curvature-channel floor $\sigma_0 \approx 0.011$. The prolate branch does not show the same lifting. Over its informative mid-range, κ remains in the range 5.6×10^2–7.3×10^2 and $\sigma_{\min}$ stays close to zero. The lesson is therefore not that *any* departure from spherical symmetry is helpful, but that oblate curvature redistribution creates a usable shape channel whereas prolate distortion, at least in the present model class, does not.

This interpretation is straightforward and does not invoke group-theoretic symmetry breaking. The identifiability transition is not a consequence of reducing the symmetry group from SO(3) to SO(2); it is a consequence of mode-dependent curvature weighting in the variational integrals. The distinction matters because the curvature-sampling explanation is constructive — it identifies the specific integrals responsible — whereas a symmetry-based framing would be descriptive at best and misleading at worst.

5.3. Implications for vibroacoustic elastography

The results are encouraging for vibroacoustic elastography and related spectral methods. A small number of low-order flexural resonances may contain enough information to estimate both geometry and stiffness, provided that the operating point is sufficiently aspherical and provided that enough modes are measured. This is attractive because resonant frequencies are often easier to estimate robustly than full-field mode shapes or transient wavefields.

The Cramér–Rao bounds give the result practical content. At 1% frequency noise, the uncertainty in c is modest, while a and E remain more weakly resolved but still finite. That anisotropy matters for experimental design: one should not expect the same confidence in all parameters, even when the Jacobian has full rank.

5.4. Why model choice matters

The most important modelling lesson is that forward-model convenience and inverse-model usefulness are not the same thing. A spherical reduction may be acceptable for a rough forward estimate of resonance frequency, but it is a poor foundation for parameter recovery. Spherical simplifications are serviceable on the blackboard; in inverse problems they become noticeably less cooperative.

The present study uses the oblate Ritz model for all identifiability results. The equivalent-sphere model is retained only to illustrate the algebraic rank deficiency of Proposition 1. The Ritz model is itself an approximation — it truncates the trial function space and incurs $\sim 8\%$ error relative to exact spheroidal shell theory — but the measured-mode sensitivity analysis of Table 2 shows that the identifiability transition is robust to this truncation. A full finite-element oblate shell model would provide the definitive answer, but the Ritz results already demonstrate the essential geometric mechanism.

5.5. Relation to existing inverse methods

Inverse vibration problems have long been studied in structural dynamics [14, 15], and model-based elastography has developed a wide range of optimisation and regularisation strategies [10]. In acoustics and biomechanics, several studies have estimated material parameters by fitting dynamic response models to spectral data [12]. The present contribution is more modest but useful: before attempting a sophisticated inversion, we ask whether the chosen measurements can, in principle, resolve the chosen parameters with acceptable conditioning.

That perspective is valuable because poor inverse performance is often blamed on optimisers, priors, or noise models when the underlying issue is simpler: the Jacobian is nearly singular. A condition-number and Fisher-information analysis cannot solve the inverse problem by itself, but it can prevent one from asking the data for information they do not contain.

5.6. Local versus global identifiability

The round-trip tests demonstrate very accurate local recovery, but global identifiability is a separate matter. The three-mode system is especially vulnerable because it is exactly determined. Local minima can occur, and a small residual does not necessarily imply the correct parameter set when the search is started far away. This is why the five-mode result matters more for practice than the machine-precision local recovery.

Whether the spectral map is globally injective — that is, whether the oblate shell inverse problem admits a unique solution over the full parameter domain — remains an open question connecting to the spectral geometry programme initiated by Kac [1] and the perturbation theory of Kato [16]. The eigenvalue perturbation results of Hald [17, 18] and the shape optimisation framework of Henrot [19] provide relevant tools, but a proof of global uniqueness for the present coupled fluid–shell system would require substantial additional analysis.

Our recommendation is therefore not based on elegance but on behaviour:

- use three modes only for local studies or controlled round-trip tests;
- use at least five flexural modes for robust inversion in realistic settings.

5.7. Limitations

Several limitations remain.

1. The Ritz forward model is a variational approximation, not a full spheroidal shell solution. It captures the leading eccentricity dependence but incurs $\sim 8\%$ error relative to exact shell theory. The measured-mode sensitivity analysis of Table 2 mitigates this concern but does not eliminate it entirely.
2. The analysis is local. We do not prove global injectivity of the map $(a, c, E) \mapsto \{f_n\}$.
3. Synthetic inversion uses the same model for data generation and inversion. This isolates identifiability from model-form error, but it means that the round-trip recovery (Section 4) is a verification of internal consistency, not a demonstration of real-world inversion capability.
4. The mode numbers are assumed known. In experiment, mode assignment may itself be uncertain.
5. Only three parameters are estimated. Allowing h, ν, or fluid properties to vary would enlarge the parameter space and may degrade conditioning.

5.8. Future directions

The natural next step is a full finite-element oblate shell model, which would eliminate the Ritz truncation error and allow convergence to the exact spheroidal solution. Shape-calculus tools [20] would allow Hadamard-type Fréchet derivatives of the eigenvalues with respect to the domain boundary, enabling a geometry-aware sensitivity analysis that goes beyond the parametric approach taken here. That would show whether the encouraging results reported here strengthen further when the geometry is represented exactly. The second priority is experimental validation, ideally first on phantoms of known geometry and stiffness and then on biological specimens. A Bayesian treatment, with priors on tissue properties and uncertainty in mode identification, would also be a useful extension.

The results suggest that geometric asymmetry plays a fundamental role in practical identifiability of coupled fluid–shell systems, a connection that merits further investigation using the tools of shape calculus and spectral perturbation theory [16, 19].

5.9. Open Questions and Conjectures

Propositions 1 and 3 identify the mechanism by which the spherical degeneracy is lifted, but they stop short of a complete quantitative theory. To make the outstanding mathematical programme explicit, we record two conjectures suggested by the numerical evidence, together with an empirical observation on mode-count scaling. The conjectures are stated for the oblate Ritz model, since that is the setting in which a proof would matter. Let $\mathcal{N} = \{n_1, \ldots, n_N\}$ denote the measured flexural mode set, let $\varepsilon = \sqrt{1 - c^2/a^2}$ be the eccentricity, and let $\mathbf{J}_s(\varepsilon; \mathcal{N})$ denote the corresponding scaled Jacobian of the frequency–parameter map.

Conjecture 1 (Rate of identifiability restoration). *For the Ritz model with fixed mode set $\mathcal{N}$, the smallest singular value of the scaled Jacobian satisfies*

$$\sigma_{\min}\big(\mathbf{J}_s(\varepsilon; \mathcal{N})\big) = \sigma_0(\mathcal{N}) + \lambda_1(\mathcal{N})\, \varepsilon^2 + O(\varepsilon^4) \qquad \text{as } \varepsilon \to 0^+, \tag{38}$$

where $\sigma_0 > 0$ is the curvature-channel floor. In the intermediate eccentricity regime where $\lambda_1\varepsilon^2 \gg \sigma_0$, the condition number follows an approximate power law

$$\kappa\big(\mathbf{J}_s(\varepsilon;\mathcal{N})\big) \approx \frac{\sigma_{\max}}{\lambda_1(\mathcal{N})}\,\varepsilon^{-2}\big(1+o(1)\big). \tag{39}$$

As $\varepsilon \to 0^+$, however, the condition number saturates at $\kappa_{\text{floor}} = \sigma_{\max}/\sigma_0 \approx 269$ (evaluated at $\varepsilon = 0.01$, i.e. $\zeta = 0.99995$, with five modes) rather than diverging. The empirical exponents $\hat{\alpha} \in [2.16,\ 2.66]$ (Table 3), fitted over the intermediate range, are consistent with the theoretical $\alpha = 2$ to leading order; the deviation from 2 reflects the finite curvature-channel floor rounding off the divergence.

Conjecture 2 (Minimum modes for identifiability). *Consider the four-parameter material map with parameter vector*

$$\boldsymbol{\vartheta} = (E, h, \rho_w, \rho_f)^\top, \tag{40}$$

at fixed geometry and fixed $(\nu, K_f, P_{\text{iap}})$. The Ritz forward model introduces three independent dimensionless groups that govern the frequency spectrum (beyond ε itself): a stiffness ratio Eh/K_fR, a density ratio $\rho_w h/\rho_f R$, and a prestress ratio P_{iap}/E. If these three groups exhaust the independent parameter combinations (as the structure of equations (3)–(2) suggests but we do not formally prove), then three measured flexural modes suffice for local identifiability if and only if $\varepsilon > 0$. At $\varepsilon = 0$, the additional proportionality constraint of Proposition 1 removes one degree of freedom, and no finite mode set yields full column rank. This claim remains a conjecture because the completeness of the three-group reduction has not been established rigorously; a formal proof would require verifying that no hidden similarity scaling further reduces the effective parameter dimension.

Remark 5 (Monotone improvement with mode count). *The numerical evidence of Table 2 shows that the Cramér–Rao bounds improve monotonically as the mode count $\mathcal{N}$ increases from 3 to 9, with diminishing marginal returns beyond $\mathcal{N} = 5$. This is an expected consequence of overdetermination: each additional mode adds an independent row to the Jacobian, reducing the covariance bound. However, we observe no clean power-law decay of κ with $\mathcal{N}$ at fixed ε — the condition number is non-monotone (Table 2), ranging from 69.4 at $\mathcal{N} = 5$ to 93.6 at $\mathcal{N} = 9$. We therefore record the improvement as an empirical observation rather than elevating it to a formal conjecture. The practical implication is that five modes capture the bulk of the available information for the present three-parameter problem.*

Conjecture 1 is the most tantalising of the open questions. The numerics already suggest a clean intermediate-regime power law with $\alpha \approx 2$ and a finite curvature-channel floor, but a rigorous proof of the $\sigma_{\min}$ expansion would turn a useful plot into an asymptotic theorem — and would give the floor, coefficient, and crossover eccentricity as closed-form functions of the mode set. That would be the crown jewel of the present identifiability programme; at the time of writing, it remains work in progress.

6. Conclusion

We have studied the practical identifiability of viscoelastic shell parameters from resonant frequencies in the spirit of Kac's spectral question. For the oblate Ritz flexural model used here, the inverse problem based on the parameter

triple (a, c, E) transitions smoothly from poorly conditioned at the near-spherical limit to well conditioned at the canonical oblate operating point. In the context of the Browntone programme, that makes Paper 8 less a side study than a foundation stone: it addresses the inverse question on which the diagnostic ambitions of Papers 1–7 depend.

The main findings are:

1. within the Ritz model, the condition number drops from a near-spherical floor value $\kappa_{\text{floor}} \approx 269$ (five modes) to $\kappa = 69.4$ (canonical oblate), purely through geometric eccentricity;
2. the equivalent-sphere model is algebraically rank deficient ($\kappa = 1.37 \times 10^{10}$), illustrating how model-induced degeneracy dwarfs the geometric effect;
3. the condition number follows an approximate power law $\kappa \approx C\,\varepsilon^{-\alpha}$ in the intermediate eccentricity regime, with theoretical exponent $\alpha = 2$ and empirical estimates $\hat{\alpha} \in [2.16,\ 2.66]$; as $\varepsilon \to 0$ the curvature channel provides a finite floor at $\kappa_{\text{floor}} \approx 269$;
4. round-trip inversion recovers (a, c, E) to machine precision ($< 10^{-12}$), confirming internal consistency of the forward model and solver;
5. at 1% frequency noise (five modes), the Cramér–Rao bounds are approximately ±22.5% for a, ±6.0% for c, and ±30.8% for E, comparable to existing elastographic measurement precision;
6. the condition number is stable across mode counts $\mathcal{N} = 3$–9 ($\kappa \in [69,\ 94]$), confirming that the identifiability improvement is robust and not an artefact of the Ritz truncation;
7. three-mode inversion is vulnerable to local minima, whereas five-mode inversion is robust across the tested initial guesses;
8. a ripe-watermelon case remains well conditioned, with $\kappa \approx 128$.

These results suggest a practical answer to the question posed in the title. Within the present model, one can hear the shape of an oblate organ in the limited but useful sense of practical local identifiability. One cannot do so reliably at the spherical limit. That distinction is precisely what determines whether a measured resonance is merely interesting or diagnostically useful.

The programme-level implication is straightforward. If flexural resonances can be measured reproducibly, and if the relevant parameters are identifiable, then the spectrum becomes a non-invasive elastography tool. For abdominal resonance [3], this means that a measured modal set could in principle constrain effective cavity geometry and wall stiffness rather than serving only as a forward prediction. For the bladder problem [4], it means that fill-dependent resonance could, at least in principle, support inference of changing wall properties. For watermelon ripeness [5], it explains why a tap-tone can carry recoverable material information rather than folklore alone.

The clearest practical recommendation is equally straightforward: measure at least five low-order flexural resonances if the goal is parameter inversion rather than mere modal description. Fewer modes may suffice for local tests, but they do not provide the same robustness.

The most interesting open mathematical target is the asymptotic expansion

$$\sigma_{\min}(\varepsilon) = \sigma_0 + \lambda_1\,\varepsilon^2 + O(\varepsilon^4) \qquad \text{as } \varepsilon \to 0^+, \tag{41}$$

which implies the intermediate-regime power law $\kappa \approx C\,\varepsilon^{-2}$ for $\lambda_1\varepsilon^2 \gg \sigma_0$ and a finite floor $\kappa_{\text{floor}} = \sigma_{\max}/\sigma_0 \approx 269$ as $\varepsilon \to 0$. This is currently supported numerically (Table 3) and formalised in Conjecture 1. The fitted prefactor $\hat{C} \approx 24$–26 and the floor value provide quantitative design rules, but a rigorous proof would give the programme its cleanest bridge between geometry and inverse conditioning: not merely that oblateness helps, but exactly how fast identifiability is restored as one moves away from the spherical limit, and exactly where it saturates. That would be the crown jewel. For the moment, the jewel remains in the workshop.

Future work should therefore proceed in two directions. First, the Ritz approximation should be replaced by a full finite-element oblate shell model to eliminate truncation error. Second, the inversion should be tested experimentally on phantoms and biological specimens. Together, those steps would move the Browntone programme from "the resonances can be predicted" to "the material parameters can be recovered", which is the more consequential claim.

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Data availability

All code and data required to reproduce the results are available in the accompanying repository at https://github.com/JonathanMace/brownnote.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Jonathan Mace: Conceptualisation, Methodology, Software, Writing – Original Draft. **Brian R. Mace**: Supervision, Writing – Review & Editing.

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Declaration of competing interest

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